CogLean

Towards a Cumulative, Machine-Checked Theory of Cognition

Jeff Shrager

October 2026

Draft for Comment

The problem: theory that doesn't accumulate

- Many computational theories of memory, learning, problem solving, skill.
- Little theory that can be **reused**:
  - a memory theory is reimplemented for each new task;
  - combining two theories means writing a third program;
  - what a theory predicts is established by running it, one setting at a time.
- Newell (1973): twenty questions with nature, answers never assembled.

Can independently developed theories, in a common formal library, be composed to derive meaningful consequences we'd otherwise need a new model to find?

Prior formal approaches to cognitive theory

Work	Formalism	What it establishes
Soar specified in Z (Milnes et al. 1992)	Z notation	a complete, low-level, non-executable specification of one architecture
Sceptic (Cooper, Fox, Farringdon & Shallice 1996)	executable specification language	models (Soar among them) stated in a language designed for cognitive models
Reconstructing ACT-R (Stewart & West 2007)	Python reimplementation	core commitments separated from implementation; alternative components
ACT-R operational semantics (Gall & Frühwirth 2018)	abstract semantics; CHR	a translation proved sound and complete; confluence tests
ACT-R as timed automata (Langenfeld et al. 2019, 2021)	timed automata	exhaustive defect analysis of models; the semantics proved correct
A common formal ground for architectures (Ragni et al. 2018)	formal framework	ACT-R and Soar embedded for comparison
Soar to PRISM (Ganeriwala et al. 2026)	Markov chains, PRISM	probabilistic model checking of stochastic models
Verbal theories as logic programs; as automata (Rohner & Kjellerstrand 2021; Finkel et al. 2025)	Prolog; automata	what a verbal theory's premises entail
Critical tests from core assumptions (Fisher et al. 2025)	proofs in prose over model classes	which processing structures ACT-R's core rules out

The analogy: Mathlib

- Mathlib, the community library of formalized mathematics in Lean, proposes no new mathematics.
- It is a **shared environment**: definitions made once, every result machine-checked, later work citing earlier results.
- A theorem about groups, once proved, is available to everyone who uses groups.

CogLean asks whether cognitive theory can be organized the same way.
It is not a new theory of cognition, nor a new modeling language.
And it is nowhere near Mathlib's scale: a first demonstration.

CogLean's layers

Applications: task models assembled from theories and library parts (three-digit addition)

Theories: EPAM, strategy choice (DOA), ACT-R declarative memory, concepts, semantic memory, ...

CogLib: representations, memories, processes, decision cycle; a retriever interface; theory-neutral phenomena and laws, with their theorems

Lean 4 (core only): the language and the proof checker; exact rational probabilities

Each layer imports only those below it, and inherits their theorems.

Four kinds of object, kept apart

1. **Mechanisms** and their postulates: definitions (how a net sorts a code; how retrieval samples).
2. **Phenomena**: predicates, stated without any mechanism. A predicate asserts nothing; it is a target.
3. **Theorems**: a mechanism produces behavior satisfying a predicate.
4. **Conditions**: situational ("x is confused with q"), empirical premises not yet explained ("associations are sharp"), well-formedness.

A theorem with a phenomenon among its hypotheses is a relation between phenomena, not a prediction. The catalog flags these mechanically.

Three capabilities

1. **Formalization**: theories as definitions, postulates and theorems, with every assumption explicit.
2. **Composition**: mechanisms reused in new contexts, and so are the *theorems* about them.
   - reusable algorithms: useful software;
   - reusable *results*: a contribution to theory.
3. **Discovery**, of a specific kind: consequences of proposed theories that their authors didn't state; unstated assumptions; results for whole classes of models; where theories diverge. (Not new hypotheses: see the end.)

Two theories, formalized on their own

EPAM (Feigenbaum & Simon)

- A discrimination net sorts a code to a stored image.
- Learning grows a test only where codes are confused.
- Proved for every net: recognition depends only on tested features; learning never disturbs other items.

DOA (Siegler & Shrager 1984)

- Associations from problems to answers; sample, state if above a criterion; else fingers, then counting.
- Proved for every setting: retrieval used with probability $1 - (1 - R)^n$; counting errors independent of the associations.

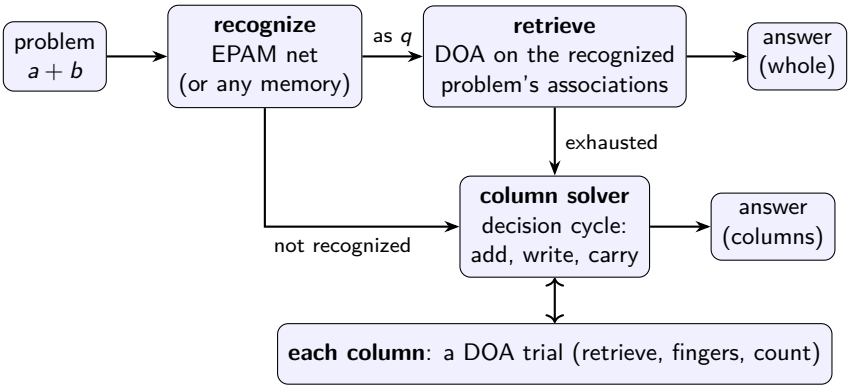
Formalization alone corrected a theory's claim

The DOA chapter: "a peaked distribution results in less frequent use of overt strategies."

- **Follows**: moving strength to the correct answer never raises retrieval errors, at any setting.
- **Does not follow**: it can *raise* overt strategy use.
  - $1 + 1$, strengths $.38, .31, .31 \rightarrow .39, .30, .31$;
  - averaged over the chapter's twelve criteria: $7/12 \rightarrow 73/120$.
  - The weakened wrong answer drops to a criterion, stops being stated, and the child turns to fingers.

The claim needs a condition the chapter doesn't state.

The application: three-digit addition



A demonstration, not a theory of arithmetic. In Lean, the composition is three definitions.

No answer supplied

- The earlier worked case used a backup that returned the correct sum: `Dist.pure p.sum`.
  - Enough to instantiate theorems about *every* backup;
  - but it supplies the answer instead of computing it.
- In the integrated model, **nothing is handed the answer**.
  - 250 for $150 + 100$ is assembled by the solver from three DOA trials and a carry rule, and is never certain.
  - Correct knowledge enters only as single-digit associations and the carry rule.

So composition has to work twice: the mechanisms run together, and their theorems transfer.

What actually happens when retrieval fails

1. **Recognize**: the EPAM net sorts the problem's code to a stored problem, possibly the wrong one.
2. **Retrieve**: DOA searches that problem's associations for an answer above the criterion.
3. **Fail**: if the search is exhausted, the backup is invoked.
4. **Solve**: the backup runs column addition on CogLib's general problem-solving machinery.
5. **Each column**: units, then tens, then hundreds; each digit sum is a separate DOA trial (retrieve, else fingers, else count).
6. **Combine**: each trial's *distribution* of answers feeds the rest of the calculation, with carrying and place value.
7. **Result**: a probability distribution over complete multi-digit answers, errors included.

`Dist.bind` composes these steps: it carries *every* possible outcome, with its probability, through the steps that follow. Nothing is sampled, and nothing looks up the right answer.

The general machinery, and its arithmetic instance

CogLib (`Process/ProblemSolving`), task-general:

- problem spaces: states; operators with preconditions and (probabilistic) effects;
- a **decision cycle**: a procedure proposes; a violated precondition is an *impasse*, fixed by repairs and critics;
- separately, **GPS**: goals, subgoals, backtracking.

MultiDigit (`Solver.lean`), the instance:

- operators: add a column, write, write and carry, finish;
- `full`: the procedure that proposes them in turn;
- `lenient`: the repair policy (no critics).

```
def solverBackup (F : Facts) (p : Problem) : Dist Nat :=
  Solver.answers F.fact Solver.full Solver.lenient p
```

`F.fact`: the DOA single-digit trial; `Solver.answers`: runs CogLib's decision cycle. The integrated model uses the **decision cycle**; GPS runs on the same space in `SolverGPS.lean` (units first; exact with exact facts) but is not part of it.

The bridge: two executable descriptions, one distribution

- `columns`: a simple, direct implementation of probabilistic column arithmetic.
- `answers`: the same task on CogLib's state-and-operator decision cycle.

```
theorem bridge (fact : Nat → Nat → Dist Nat) (p : Problem) :
    answers fact full lenient p = columns fact p
```

- **Proved**, not tested: identical answer distributions for *every* problem and *every* single-digit process.
- So every theorem about `columns` (place value, a column error as a single-digit error in place) holds for the solver.
- It equates *outputs*, not internal processes: the two still differ as accounts of what a child does.

How theorems compose

- **The bridge** (previous slide): every column theorem transfers to the solver.
- **Associativity**: every arrow is a two-stage draw; draws regroup, so a component's theorem holds inside the whole.
- **Well-formedness, inherited**: the composed trial is a probability distribution, proved by chaining lemmas from three packages:
  - retrieval, a DOA trial, the column procedure, the bridge;
  - total mass 1, *and* nonnegative weights.

These are library facts, not psychology; they are what let results transfer.

Confident errors

If q is recognized as itself, x is confused with q, q's associations are **sharp**, and their sums differ:

(i) whole-problem retrieval never errs on q;

(ii) every whole-problem answer to x is wrong;

(iii) x reaches the solver *exactly as often* as q.

- **Neither theory alone**: in DOA, errors and backup use come from one distribution; recognition gives x another problem's distribution.
- **Reused**: a one-line proof, from CogLib's theorem for *any* task with problems, a familiar set and a backup.
- **Conditions**: confusion (derived for learned nets); sharpness (assumed, not yet explained); positive strengths.

In words: the theorem on the next slide

CogLib's `confident_errors`, for *any* task, memory and backup:

- **Parameters**: how problems are coded, what memory calls up (`retrieve`), the associations (`str`), the criterion and search length, and the backup.
- **Hypotheses**:
  - strengths have positive totals; the backup is a proper distribution;
  - q calls up itself, for certain (`hq`);
  - x calls up q, for certain (`hx`): the confusion;
  - q's associations are sharp (`hs`); the correct answers differ (`hne`).
- **Conclusion**: the *confusion-error pattern*, a phenomenon defined once in CogLib, apart from any mechanism: three equations, (i)–(iii) of the last slide.
- **Proof**: three lines, citing three earlier lemmas.

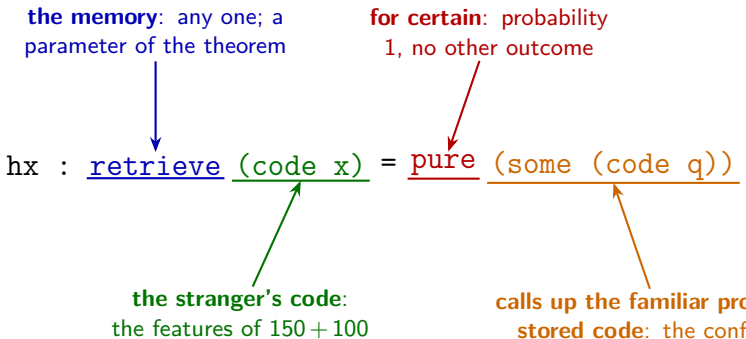
The theorem, in Lean

```
theorem confident_errors (correct : P → A) (x q : P) (hT : ∀ y, total as (str y) ≠ 0)
    (hbx : mass (backup x) = 1) (hbq : mass (backup q) = 1)
    (hq : retrieve (code q) = pure (some (code q)))
    (hx : retrieve (code x) = pure (some (code q)))
    (hs : Sharp str cc (code q) (correct q)) (hne : correct x ≠ correct q) :
    Phenomena.ConfusionErrorPattern (recognizeRetrieve code retrieve str as cc n backup)
      (wholeWrong correct) isWhole isBackup x q := by
  refine ⟨confusion_gives_neighbours_answer code retrieve str as cc n backup
      correct q q (hT _) hq hs,
    wrong_eq_whole_of_sharp code retrieve str as cc n backup
      correct x _ _ (hT _) hx hs hne, ?_⟩
  rw [backup_prob_certain code retrieve str as cc n backup x _ hx hbx hT,
    backup_prob_certain code retrieve str as cc n backup q _ hq hbq hT]

def ConfusionErrorPattern (trial : P → Dist O) (wholeWrong : P → O → Bool)
    (isWhole isBackup : O → Bool) (x q : P) : Prop :=
  prob (trial q) (wholeWrong q) = 0 ∧
    prob (trial x) (wholeWrong x) = prob (trial x) isWhole ∧
    prob (trial x) isBackup = prob (trial q) isBackup
```

Verbatim from CogLib (`Process/RecognizeRetrieve`, `Phenomena/ConfusionErrors`). The multi-digit version is a one-line instance.

One clause, unpacked: the confusion



- **EPAM**: holds for the net learned from $100 + 100$ and $100 + 200$ (checked); every learned net recognizes its own images.
- **ACT-R**: *never* holds, because `pure` is too strong: retrieval is graded, never certain. That is why the theorem doesn't apply to it.

Equal is not low

- The theorem gives *equal* solver use for x and q, not *low* solver use.
- The rate is $(1 - R_q)^n$, with R_q the chance one search of q's associations clears the criterion.
- If $R_q \geq r$, the confused problem reaches the solver with probability at most $(1 - r)^n$.
- With flat associations on q, the same theorem holds, and the errors are not confident.

Here $R_q = 45/46$, $n = 1$: the solver is reached $1/46$ of the time.

Two more consequences of the composition

Whole-problem errors don't depend on the solver (every setting)

- Improving column skill cannot reduce errors from mistaken recognition.

Two sources of error on a confused problem (given the conditions)

- Whole route: always the neighbour's sum.
- Column route: exhaustion $\times$ the solver's own error rate, which comes from the single-digit DOA trials.
- If the other columns are exact, a column error is a single-digit error in place, off by $10^j\delta$. But columns can err together, errors can carry, and they can even cancel: units 10 and tens 4 still give 250.

Swapping the memory: EPAM versus ACT-R

	EPAM net	ACT-R memory
$150 + 100$ answered 200 by retrieval	$45/46$	$225/529 \approx .43$
$150 + 100$: solver invoked	$1/46$	$383/1058 \approx .36$
solver correct, *given* invoked	$\approx .656$	$\approx .656$
correct overall (invoked *and* correct)	$\approx .014$	$\approx .238$
practiced $100 + 100$: overall errors	$\approx .0073$	$\approx .334$
after also studying $100 + 300$	unchanged	$\approx .616$
memory laws (every setting)	determinacy, certainty, stability	none of them

- The confident-error theorem holds for *any* memory with the three laws.
- For ACT-R it doesn't apply. That doesn't mean ACT-R can't err similarly (it does, gradedly); the exact pattern fails, and at this setting that is proved (`setting_actr_not_pattern`).

One memory for both levels

Column facts from the *same* memory as whole problems: each digit pair $d + e$ is coded as a problem, recognized, and retrieved in the same strength table; fingers and counting if that fails.

- **The old model is a special case**: a pair recognized as itself gives exactly the DOA fact (`memFact_self`), so every earlier theorem carries over.
- **Confident errors one level down**: a pair taken for another states the other's sum (`column_confident_errors`), with no new proof.
- **Noninterference needs a condition**: EPAM's practice stays undisturbed *given* that the problem's digit pairs were learned (`shared_learning_preserves_trial`). The old theorem held the solver fixed; here learning could change it.

One memory: the numbers

Memory studies $0+0$, $5+0$, $1+1$, then $100+100$, $100+200$.

	EPAM	ACT-R, separate table	ACT-R, one memory
$0+0$ answered 5 (retrieves $5+0$)	0	0	120/2167
$150+100$: solver invoked	1/46	$\approx .407$	$\approx .407$
solver correct, *given* invoked	$\approx .656$	$\approx .656$	$\approx .385$
correct overall	$\approx .014$	$\approx .267$	$\approx .157$
errors on practiced $100+100$	$\approx .0073$	$\approx .334$	$\approx .386$

- The middle column is a control: same five items in memory, but the solver doesn't use it.
- Extra items alone: *more* correct ($.238 \rightarrow .267$). Sharing the memory: fewer (.157).
- ACT-R without retrieval as use; finger counting is an implausible column fallback.

What each result rests on

Kind	Examples
Library facts	the bridge; the composed trial is a probability distribution
Compositional deductions (every setting)	whole-problem errors independent of the solver; solver use is $(1 - R_q)^n$
Conditional	confident errors; two sources of error; any memory with three laws
At chosen settings	$45/46$, $1/46$, $\approx .656$, $\approx .014$, the ACT-R column

None of these is yet an empirical finding about people. The numbers are illustrations, not fits.

Checking the formalization: a blind simulation

- A prose specification, no Lean; preregistered checks; a fresh agent wrote a simulator from the prose alone.
- **Agreement**: every check whose hypothesis arose passed; 243 frequencies matched Lean exactly.
- **Found what proof didn't**:
  - five theorems' hypotheses were *unrealized* in the tested learning histories (not shown unreachable);
  - a gap at zero total strength;
  - a predicted learning sequence depends on an unstated assumption: a new problem's initial associations.

Model verification and theoretical deduction

- **Simulation** samples executions.
- **Probabilistic model checking** (PRISM; Soar to PRISM, Ganeriwala et al. 2026) analyzes a specified state-transition model exhaustively; it is formal verification, and can treat parameters symbolically.
- **Deductive proof** (CogLean) establishes results for whole classes of models satisfying theoretical assumptions.

The contrast is *model verification* versus *theoretical deduction*. Complementary, not competitors.

CogLean's claim is not formal methods (see the prior work), but the combination: a shared, cumulative library with reusable proofs, cross-theory composition, and deductive discovery.

Relationship to cognitive architectures

- Not an alternative to Soar, ACT-R, or the Common Model of Cognition.
- A possible **formal foundation** for expressing, composing and reasoning about their mechanisms and architectural commitments.
- The present example composes locally, for one task, without committing to a general architecture.
- Longer term: formalize **architectural constraints themselves**, so their implications can be proved and architectures compared in one framework.

What a proof shows, and what it doesn't

- Lean guarantees **validity**: conclusions follow from premises.
- Not **empirical adequacy**: whether the premises describe people.
- Not **explanation**: whether the premises already contain the phenomenon.
- Example: a serial-position result whose mechanism was a bowed schedule. Valid, nearly empty. Now derived from an attention rule, which also gives the isolation effect.
- An explicit audit sorts results as definitional, close, derived, compositional.

What CogLean is, and isn't

It doesn't

- generate hypotheses or theories: people (or AIs) propose them;
- find phenomena in data, or fit parameters;
- show that a theory is true of people;
- decide whether a derivation is an explanation;
- replace simulation or experiment.

It does

- check whether a proposed consequence follows, and from exactly what;
- find counterexamples to informal claims (peaking);
- expose unstated assumptions and conditions;
- say for which class of models a result holds;
- let proved results be reused across theories and tasks.

"Discovery" here means finding out what does, or doesn't, follow from theories people propose.

Limitations, and next

Limitations

- Strengths chosen, not learned; sharpness assumed.
- Error-free carrying; independent columns; finger counting as the column fallback.
- ACT-R without retrieval as use.
- Nonnegativity proved for this model, not library-wide.
- Scalability: exact finite distributions.
- No contact with data yet.

Next

- Derive associations from learning histories, so sharpness is a theorem.
- Learning across whole trials: prove the learning sequence.
- Restate the unrealized predictions in terms of tested features.
- Retrieval that changes memory, carried through the solver.
- Architectural constraints; other domains.

Take-home

- Cognitive theories can be stated once, in a shared formal library, with their consequences proved.
- Independently formalized theories compose, and so do their **theorems**.
- Composition derives consequences none of the parts states; formalization exposes what the theories didn't say.
- Every result is labelled: library fact, compositional deduction, conditional, or illustrative.

The goal: a cumulative theoretical science, in which cognitive constructs and their proved properties are reused across models, tasks and traditions.

`https://github.com/jeffshrager/CogLean`